

01

THE PROBLEM OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Fact: An ICML 2026 paper on Sanskrit–English translation reports that purely statistical generation can cause semantic drift in culturally embedded and ritual concepts, and proposes dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary-grounded decoding to preserve sacred entities and terminology. □□ Inference: This contemporary translation problem illustrates a core philosophical point: religious meaning is not exhausted by word substitution.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Master verdict: Religious utterances are often assertoric, symbolic and performative together; a mixed account preserves realist intent while acknowledging that transcendence requires non-literal modes of predication.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Context, use, symbolic reference and a tradition’s conceptual grammar affect what an utterance means, though an AI translation benchmark does not settle whether the original claims are truth-apt.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: "HOW (Analogy/Symbol/Negation) × WHETHER (Cognitive/Non-cognitive)." Analogy & symbol rescue meaning.

ANSWER LINE: □ Fact: An ICML 2026 paper on Sanskrit–English translation reports that purely statistical generation can cause semantic drift in culturally embedded and ritual concepts, and proposes dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary-grounded decoding to preserve sacred entities and terminology. □□ Inference: This contemporary translation problem illustrates a core philosophical point: religious meaning is not exhausted by word substitution.

02

MEANING, REFERENCE AND TRANSCENDENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Meaning, Reference And Transcendence is analysed by relating Meaning to Reference, then testing the relationship through Transcendence and Univocal.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Need a middle way. □ The Logical Positivist attack (Ayer): "God exists" is unverifiable → literally meaningless (see Paper-I Logical Positivism).

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human...

ANSWER LINE: Religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human concepts can be meaningful without reducing their object to finite categories.

03

ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND NEGATIVE THEOLOGY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Two types: □ Analogy of attribution — "God is good" because God is the cause/source of goodness in creatures.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Two types: □ Analogy of attribution — "God is good" because God is the cause/source of goodness in creatures.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

So "good" applies proportionally, truly but not identically. → preserves meaning without anthropomorphism. (b) Symbol (Tillich — 2023, 2025 PYQ): □ Religious language is symbolic, not literal.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

"God" is not a being among beings but the "Ground of Being" / Being-Itself; to take symbols literally is idolatry. □□ Tillich caution (preserve this; do not simplify it).

ANSWER LINE: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism. (a) Analogy (Aquinas — 2024 PYQ): religious language is analogical — between univocal and equivocal.

04

COGNITIVISM, NON-COGNITIVISM AND FALSIFICATION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Cognitivist (realist): religious statements are genuine truth-claims — "God exists" is true or false, asserting a fact about reality (Aquinas, Hick, Swinburne). □ Non-cognitivist: religious statements do not state facts; they express something else: □ R.B.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

"Does the cognitivist account lead to contradiction?" (2024 — Braithwaite); □□ Braithwaite argues the cognitivist (factual) reading runs into the verification problem (unverifiable → meaningless), so he reduces religious language to moral-conative use to save it.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Cognitivist (realist): religious statements are genuine truth-claims — "God exists" is true or false, asserting a fact about reality (Aquinas, Hick, Swinburne). □ Non-cognitivist: religious statements do not state facts; they express something else: □ R.B.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Braithwaite (2024 PYQ): religious assertions are declarations of a moral intention / commitment to a way of life (+ associated stories), not factual claims.

ANSWER LINE: Cognitivism treats religious claims as truth-apt, whereas non-cognitivism emphasises attitude, commitment or use; these are semantic functions, not automatically exclusive categories.

05

TILLICH, AQUINAS, VIA NEGATIVA AND LANGUAGE-GAMES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while non-cognitivists (Braithwaite/Wittgenstein) capture its practical/moral force but at the cost of its truth-claim; the believer’s own intent is cognitivist.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The operative mechanism is that religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist).

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist).

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist).

ANSWER LINE: □ The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while non-cognitivists (Braithwaite/Wittgenstein) capture its practical/moral force but at the cost of its truth-claim; the believer’s own intent is cognitivist.

06

ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND FOUNDATIONAL POSITIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Aquinas locates God-talk between univocal sameness and equivocal disconnection through analogy. □ Tillich treats religious symbols as participatory and God as being-itself rather than one being among others. □ Braithwaite analyses religious assertion through commitment to a moral way of life and its sustaining stories. □ Wittgensteinian approaches interpret religious meaning through use within a form of life. □ The Upaniṣadic formula yato vāco nivartante marks the limit of objectifying speech; Advaita also deploys neti neti and indirect indication.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that [Symbolic] "Is religious language symbolic? / Tillich on symbol." (2025, 2023) → §2(b). [Analogical]...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: [Symbolic] "Is religious language symbolic? / Tillich on symbol." (2025, 2023) → §2(b). [Analogical]...

ANSWER LINE: [Symbolic] "Is religious language symbolic? / Tillich on symbol." (2025, 2023) → §2(b). [Analogical] "Analogical nature of religious language (Aquinas)." (2024) → §2(a). [Cog/non-cog] "Distinguish cognitivist & non-cognitivist accounts (Braithwaite / 'God exists')." (2024, 2022) → §3. [Wittgenstein] "Wittgenstein on the non-cognitive nature of religious language." (2023) → §3. [Advaita] "Anirvacanīyātā & the nature of religious language." (2025) → §2(d) + §9.5. [Secular vs religious] "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m) → §9.6 — function, not vocabulary, [Symbol–mysticism] "Does religious symbolism lead to mysticism?" (2019, 20m) → §9.7 — answer whether and how, and include the negative case. [Transcendent referent] "Religious symbols as transcendent referent mediating into the cultural, spatial and temporal

07

INDIAN AND WESTERN STRATEGIES OF RELIGIOUS SPEECH

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Indian And Western Strategies Of Religious Speech is analysed by relating Indian to Western Strategies Of Religious Speech, then testing the relationship through Univocity and Nyāya.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The operative mechanism is that a complete answer must keep two axes separate.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that a complete answer must keep two axes separate.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: a complete answer must keep two axes separate.

ANSWER LINE: A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.